



Suriname

Detailed Assessment Results

I. Legal Frameworks 1.27 / 5

II. Mining policies 3.17 / 5

III. Investigation and enforcement 2.19 / 5

Total score 6.63 / 15.00



Each coloured segment represents one dimension. Grey shows remaining headroom to 15.

About this scorecard

The **Amazon Mining Policy Scoreboard**, led by Amazon Conservation Association, evaluates national gold mining governance across Amazon countries. Each country is assessed across three dimensions — **Legal Frameworks**, **Mining Policies**, and **Investigation & Enforcement** — each worth up to 5 points, for a maximum total of **15 points**. Within each dimension, five categories (each normalised 0–1) are evaluated through multiple criteria.

Suriname received a total score of **6.63 out of 15.00**, ranking **7th out of 8 Amazon countries** assessed. The pages that follow present the full set of criteria, justifications, and sources organised by dimension and category.

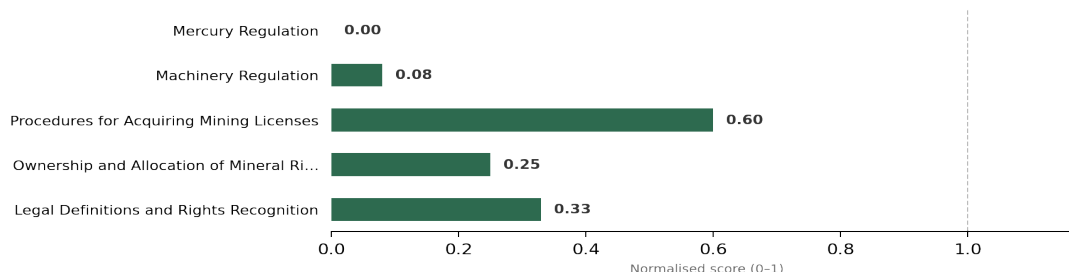
■ Legal Frameworks	■ Mining policies	■ Investigation and enforcement
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This assessment was produced by Amazon Conservation as part of the [Amazon Mining Policy Scoreboard](#), a component of [Amazon Mining Watch](#). The assessment for each country was conducted with support from, respectively: Conservación Amazonica – ACEAA (Bolivia), Instituto Centro de Vida (Brazil), Fundación para la Conservación y el Desarrollo Sostenible (Colombia), Fundación Ecociencia (Ecuador), Amazon Conservation Team (Guyana and Suriname), Conservación Amazonica – ACCA (Peru), and SOS Orinoco (Venezuela).

I. Legal Frameworks

1.27 / 5.00

Category scores



A. Legal Definitions and Rights Recognition

Score: 0.33 / 1.00

Does national legislation clearly define the legal conditions under which gold mining is permitted, and distinguish them from activities considered illegal?

1.0

Criterion 1

Justification

Suriname's Mining Decree 1986 clearly establishes that mining activities are only permitted if they comply with lawful regulations and after rights have been granted by the competent authority [1]. This implies a distinction between legal, permitted mining activities and those conducted without such authorization, which would be considered illegal. The decree sets the foundational legal conditions for mining operations.

Sources

Mining Decree 1986 (Decree of 8 May 1986 containing general rules concerning the exploration and exploitation of minerals), Article 2, paragraph 6. URL: <https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwhuuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>

Does national legislation provide a clear legal definition of artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM), distinct from large-scale or industrial mining?

0.0

Criterion 2

Justification

Suriname's Mining Decree of 1986 defines "small-scale mining" as operations with small capital investment, low technological sophistication, and at least 51% ownership by Surinamese citizens [1]. However, the National Action Plan (NAP) for ASGM notes that the mining legislation does not provide a direct definition of "artisanal" mining [2]. The lack of a clear distinction and definition for artisanal mining, while having one for small-scale mining, results in a score of 0

Sources

1. *Mining Decree 1986, Article 1g.*
2. *First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname, December 2023, Glossary of Terms. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf*

Does the legal framework set distinct conditions or restrictions for mining activities in Indigenous territories, protected areas, mining exclusion zones and community lands, including provisions related to consent, well-informed prior consultation, or land tenure?

0.0

Criterion 3

Justification

Suriname's legal framework is currently in flux regarding the rights of Indigenous and Tribal communities. A proposed land rights bill has sparked controversy because it would replace the principle of Free, Prior and Informed Consent (FPIC) with a consultation process that does not grant communities decision-making power [1]. The bill would also allow the government to grant mining concessions on Indigenous and Tribal land if deemed in the "public interest." This indicates that while there are discussions and proposed conditions, they do not yet provide clear and enforceable restrictions on mining activities in these territories.

Sources

Land rights bill in Suriname sparks outrage in Indigenous communities. Mongabay. URL: <https://news.mongabay.com/2025/02/land-rights-bill-in-suriname-sparks-outrage-in-indigenous-communities/>

B. Ownership and Allocation of Mineral Rights

Score: 0.25 / 1.00

Does the law allocate ownership rights over minerals, including gold?

1.0

Criterion 4

Justification

The Mining Decree of 1986 explicitly states that all minerals within the territory of Suriname, including its territorial sea and subsoil, are the property of the state [1]. This provision clearly allocates the ownership of all minerals, including gold, to the state.

Sources

Mining Decree 1986, Article 2, paragraph 2

Are there transparent and publicly accessible registries of mining titles, licenses, or concessions for ASM (mining cadastres)?

0.0

Criterion 5

Justification

Suriname does not have a publicly accessible mining concession registry. The Geology and Mining Department (GMD) processes mining rights applications, but there is no systematic register that displays the status or outcome of these applications. While there are efforts to improve transparency in the extractive sector, the current system does not provide a public access to mining concession information.

Sources

1. Suriname. EITI. URL: <https://eiti.org/countries/suriname>
 2. Suriname, 2023. EITI. URL: <https://eiti.org/document/23630>
 3. Suriname achieves fairly low score in EITI implementation. EITI. URL: <https://eiti.org/news/suriname-achieves-fairly-low-score-eiti-implementation>
-

Is there an official and up-to-date mining registry that includes information allowing authorities to prevent overlapping concessions with existing rights, such as other titles, protected areas, or indigenous lands?

0.0

Criterion 6

Justification

While Suriname has a GLIS register for mining and forest concessions which is not public, the National REDD+ Strategy of Suriname explicitly states that there is "no checkpoint to identify overlaps" between these concessions and other land uses [1]. This indicates a significant gap in the system, as it does not effectively prevent overlapping concessions with protected areas or Indigenous lands. Reports also highlight instances of concessions being granted on Indigenous lands and illegal mining occurring in these territories, further demonstrating the lack of preventative measures [2, 3]. There is a National Land Monitoring System of Suriname where concessions are visualized. However, the information is not up to date for some years.

Sources

1. National REDD+ Strategy of Suriname. URL: https://redd.unfccc.int/files/national_redd_strategy_of_suriname_en_web.pdf
2. Suriname is selling its gold and timber – at the cost of tribal ... Mongabay. URL: <https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2024/feb/21/suriname-loggers-miners-forests-deforestation-saamak-a>
3. How illegal gold mining affects Suriname's Wayana ... Caribois. URL: <https://caribois.org/2024/03/how-illegal-gold-mining-affects-surinames-wayana-indigenous-territory/>
<https://gonini.sbb.sr/>

Is there a formalization process in place for ASM workers operating without a formal permit, license and/or concession?

0.0

Criterion 7

Justification

Despite extensive research into Suriname's mining regulations and EITI reports, no clear, comprehensive, and publicly documented formalization process for artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) workers operating without formal permits, licenses, or concessions could be identified. While there are discussions and projects aimed at improving the ASGM sector, a defined process for formalization of existing informal miners is not readily apparent in the consulted sources [1, 2, 3].

Sources

1. Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative Suriname - EITI-SR. URL: <https://eitipuriname.gov.sr/en/>
2. First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname, December 2023. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf
3. Suriname, 2023. EITI. URL: <https://eiti.org/document/23630>

C. Procedures for Acquiring Mining Licenses

Score: 0.60 / 1.00

Are there clear procedures for acquiring rights on ASM for gold?

Justification

While there is a general application process for mining rights that begins at the Geological and Mining Department (GMD) and is identified with a serial number [1], and formal small and medium-scale mining is based on licenses assigned by the Ministry of Natural Resources (Min NH) under the Mining Decree 1986 [2], there are indications that these procedures may not be entirely clear or accessible for all artisanal and small-scale miners. Many small-scale miners reportedly operate without permits [3], suggesting that the existing procedures might not be sufficiently clear or tailored to facilitate formal acquisition of rights for all ASM.

Sources

1. Register of Mining Licenses. EITI Suriname. URL: https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/en/eiti-suriname-reports/eiti-suriname-report-2016/register-of_x0002_mining-licenses/
2. Gold mining. EITI Suriname. URL: <https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/en/about-suriname/history-of-mining-industry/gold-mining/>
3. Socio-technical study of small-scale gold mining in Suriname. ResearchGate. URL: https://research.vu.nl/files/275396183/Socio-technical_study_of_small-scale_gold_minin_g_in_Suriname.pdf

Is there a legal framework that requires the buyer of gold to verify its legal origin?

Justification

There is no structured system that promotes traceability where the gold originates from in ASM. Gold buyers may lawfully purchase gold only if it originates from a holder of a valid concession or small-scale mining license. The Mining Decree does not explicitly say “buyers must conduct due diligence”, it makes legality of origin a condition for lawful trade, which in practice obliges buyers to verify that gold is sourced from licensed operations. However, according to the environmental law, it is mandatory for companies that purchase gold to further process this, to register and obtain a certification of registration from the National Environmental Authority.

Sources

- <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
- https://www.cbvs.sr/images/content/pdf/Richtlijnen/Spaarinstellingen/2023/Act_on_preventing_and_combating_ML_and_TF.pdf
- <https://www.starnieuws.com/index.php/welcome/index/nieuwsitem/84996>
- https://fnbc.sr/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/20250303_FINALE-VERSIE-Algemene-Voorwaarden_v9.pdf
- <https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/NMA-overhandigt-registratiebewijzen-aan-goudopkoop-bedrijven>
- https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Are specific environmental licensing procedures established for ASM, including simplified or tailored requirements?

Justification

Legislation applicable to gold mining and its environmental and health management is spread out over several laws and regulations. The Mining Decree of 1986 mentions the procedures to obtain license for small scale mining, whereas the Environmental Framework Law of 2020 (and subsequent updates, including the shift to the National Environmental Authority or NMA) provides the legal basis for issuing environmental permits. However, according to the First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale goldmining in Suriname, there is no specific legislation for the ASM sector.

Sources

<https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwhuuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>

<https://www.dna.sr/wetgeving/surinaamse-wetten/wetten-na-2005/milieu-raamwet/>

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Is there a national, regional, or state government entity that oversees compliance with the implementation of artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) operations' commitments in accordance with mining environmental licenses?

1.0

Criterion 11

Justification

The National Environmental Authority (NMA), previously known as the National Institute for Environment and Development in Suriname (NIMOS) is actively working on finalizing environmental regulations, and there are ongoing efforts to develop specific procedures for the artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM) sector [1, 2]. However, the available information does not clearly confirm the full establishment and widespread implementation of distinct, simplified, or tailored environmental licensing procedures specifically for ASM. While progress is being made, the current state suggests partial implementation rather than fully established and accessible procedures.

Sources

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/NMA-overhandigt-registratiebewijzen-aan-goudopkoop-bedrijven>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/regionale-conferentie-belicht-duurzame-alternatieven-voor-kwikgebruik-in-kleinschalige-goudmijnbouw>

Ministry of Natural Resources of Suriname. Scoping Report. URL:

<https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Scoping-Report-FINAL-Incl-Appendix.pdf>

Are mining concessions or licenses granted for a fixed period with mandatory reassessment before extension? *0.5 may be given in cases where the reassessment is mandatory, even when there is no fixed period for the mining concession

1.0

Criterion 12

Justification

Yes, mining concessions and licenses in Suriname are granted for fixed periods, with requirements for renewal or extension, typically based on the 1986 Mining Decree and negotiated Mineral Agreements. Extension applications must be submitted within the valid term, and for medium-scale operations, a feasibility report and compliance update are mandatory for extension. Exploration and exploitation concessions have defined terms. Extensions are possible but must be requested prior to expiration, ensuring the license remains valid while the application is processed. For transition to exploitation or during extension, applicants must provide reports on activities, financial commitments, and project feasibility. International investors often negotiate specific agreements (Mineral Agreements) which are ratified by the National Assembly to set custom, longer-term terms for specific large projects.

Sources

<https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwhuuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>

<https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/en/eiti-suriname-reports/eiti-suriname-report-2017/bid-rounds-mining-allocation-of-licensing-and-contracts-and-contract-disclosure-mining/>

<https://eiti.org/countries/suriname#:~:text=Suriname%20EITI%20reports%20and%20contracts,register%20for%20the%20mining%20sector.>

<https://minehutte.com/jurisdiction/suriname/#:~:text=Few%20international%20investors%20and%20operators,standalone%20laws%20in%20the%20country.>

Is the use of machinery in ASM subject to regulation and licensing?

0.0

Criterion 13

Justification

Suriname's First National Action Plan (NAP) on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining explicitly states that Suriname does not have legislation specifically for the ASGM sector, and the legal framework contains no regulations about the sale and general use of machinery [1]. This indicates a lack of specific regulation and licensing for the use of machinery in ASM.

Sources

1. *First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname*, December 2023, page 20. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Are environmental impact assessments (EIAs) required for mechanized ASM operations?

0.0

Criterion 14

Justification

The NMA is responsible for the environmental impact assessment (EIA) process for all activities concerning the environment. The EIA process involves several phases, including screening, scoping, environmental impact analysis, assessment, and decision-making. The NMA ensures compliance with the Environmental Framework Law and provides guidance on the procedures to be followed. However, given that Suriname lacks specific legislation for the Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) sector and does not have regulations concerning the sale and general use of machinery in this sector [1], it is highly improbable that specific Environmental Impact Assessments (EIAs) would be mandated for mechanized ASM operations. Previous research for Criterion 12 also indicated a lack of clear mandatory EIAs for ASM over large areas. Therefore, there is no evidence to suggest that EIAs are required for mechanized ASM operations. In the NMA EIA repository no EIA reports can be found for ASM operations.

Sources

First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname, December 2023, page 20. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf
<https://sites.google.com/view/nma-mea-eia-repository/home>

Are there governmental controls on the import, sale, or leasing of mining machinery?

0.5

Criterion 15

Justification

There are in general governmental controls when it comes to machinery in general, but not specified to mining machinery. Suriname's First National Action Plan (NAP) on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining explicitly states that the legal framework contains no regulations regarding the sale and general use of machinery in the ASGM sector [1]. This lack of regulation extends to governmental controls on the import, sale, or leasing of such machinery. In 2011 the Ordering Gold Sector (OGS) was established to register small scale mining operations and the relevant mining equipment, however they had weak enforcement due to several challenges.

Sources

1. *First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname*, December 2023, page 20. URL:

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://gov.sr/thema/kleinschalige-mijnbouw/>

https://surinamenieuwscentrale.com/ordering-kleinschalige-goudsector-heeft-nog-lange-weg-te-gaan#google_vignette

Is there a national or subnational registry for heavy machinery used in mining?

0.0

Criterion 16

Justification

Based on the available information, there is no evidence of a national or subnational registry specifically for heavy machinery used in mining in Suriname. The First National Action Plan (NAP) on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining indicates a general lack of legislation and regulation concerning machinery in the ASGM sector [1]. Without specific regulations for the sale and use of machinery, it is highly improbable that a comprehensive registry for such equipment exists or is maintained.

Sources

First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname, December 2023, page 20. URL:

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Are there transparent and publicly accessible registries or databases of licenses or permits granted for the use of machinery in ASM operations?

0.0

Criterion 17

Justification

As established in the assessment for Criterion 15, Suriname's legal framework lacks specific legislation for the Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) sector and contains no regulations concerning the sale and general use of machinery [1]. Consequently, there are no transparent and publicly accessible registries or databases of licenses or permits granted for the use of machinery in ASM operations.

Sources

First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname, December 2023, page 20. URL:

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Are operators required to equip heavy machinery with GPS or other tracking devices for monitoring purposes?

0.0

Criterion 18

Justification

There is no evidence in the consulted sources, including the First National Action Plan (NAP) on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining and various EITI reports, to suggest that operators in Suriname are legally required to equip heavy mining machinery with GPS or other tracking devices for monitoring purposes. While there are efforts to use Earth Observation techniques for monitoring ASGM activities by the government, and commercial solutions for GPS

tracking exist, this does not translate into a mandatory legal obligation for operators [1, 2].

Sources

1. *First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname*, December 2023. URL:
https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf
2. *Mapping the big picture: Using earth observations to monitor environmental impact of gold mining. Data for SDGs*. URL:
<https://www.data4sdgs.org/blog/mapping-big-picture-using-earth-observations-monitor-environmental-impact-gold-mining-0>

E. Mercury Regulation

Score: 0.00 / 1.00

Is mercury import, sale, and use regulated under national law?

0.0

Criterion 19

Justification

The import of mercury reportedly requires a license, however the critical aspects of sale and use are not regulated under national law according to the NAP on Artisanal and Small-scale goldmining in Suriname. The National Environmentsl Authority does have a checklist for the import of chemical substances that need approval before being imported which is mentioned in the environmental framework law. The law has certain regulations regarding the import, sale and use of chemical substances that can cause damage to the environment, but does not mention mercury spceifically. Because there is no regulation specifically for mercury, a score of 0 is assigned.

Sources

- https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf
<https://www.nmasuriname.org/NMA%20checklist%20voor%20de%20import%20van%20chemische%20stoffen.pdf>
https://www.nmasuriname.org/S.B.%202024%20no.%2056_%20WET%20van%2021%20mei%202024-%20houdend%20wijziging%20van%20de%20Milieu%20Raamwet%20-S.B.%202020%20no.%20.pdf

Are there specific restrictions or bans on mercury use in ASM?

0.0

Criterion 20

Justification

While Suriname has conducted a Minamata Initial Assessment (MIA) which identified the need to monitor and register mercury imports [1], and has a National Action Plan (NAP) for Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) [2], the NAP explicitly states that the legal framework contains no regulations about the sale and use of mercury [2]. Furthermore, reports indicate that legal import permits for mercury have not been issued since 2003, suggesting that any existing import registry is either defunct or ineffective in tracking actual mercury flows, which are largely illicit [3]. Therefore, there are no comprehensive and effective national or subnational registries for mercury imports, sales, and use.

Sources

1. *Suriname MinaMata initial assessMent*. Minamata Convention. URL:
https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/minamata_initial_assessmant/Suriname-MIA-2020.pdf
2. *First National Action Plan on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining in Suriname*, December 2023, page 20. URL:
https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Is there a system for tracking the origin, distribution, and final use of mercury?

0.0

Criterion 21

Justification

Despite Suriname's accession to the Minamata Convention and the development of a National Action Plan (NAP) for Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM), there is a significant lack of clear legal procedures for the storage, transport, and disposal of mercury and mercury-containing waste. Multiple sources confirm this gap. The OAS report from March 2023 explicitly states, "At present, Suriname has no legal framework on mercury" [1]. Similarly, the political ecology report on mercury in Suriname notes that "there are no legal instruments that specifically mention mercury" [2]. While the Minamata Convention addresses interim storage and disposal, and efforts are underway to adopt standards under the Environmental Law, these have not yet translated into clear, implemented national procedures [3].

Sources

1. SURINAME. OAS. URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
2. The political ecology of mercury within the small-scale gold mining sector in Suriname. IUCN NL. URL: https://www.iucn.nl/app/uploads/2021/03/regional_mercury_report_suriname.pdf
3. The Republic of Suriname Measures to Implement the Minamata Convention on Mercury. Minamata Convention. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/notification/Suriname_30-4.pdf

Are there procedures in place for the seizure, transport, and final disposal of confiscated mercury, especially following operations against illegal gold mining?

0.0

Criterion 22

Justification

Despite Suriname's commitment to the Minamata Convention and the development of a National Action Plan (NAP) for Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM), there is no clear legal framework or specific provisions for the remediation of mercury-contaminated sites. While the NAP mentions a systematic evaluation of communities within ASGM areas for risk assessment and monitoring [1], and the Minamata Convention itself addresses contaminated sites, the available sources do not detail national legal instruments or clear procedures for the actual remediation process. Previous research (Criterion 24) also highlighted a general absence of a legal framework for mercury management in Suriname [2].

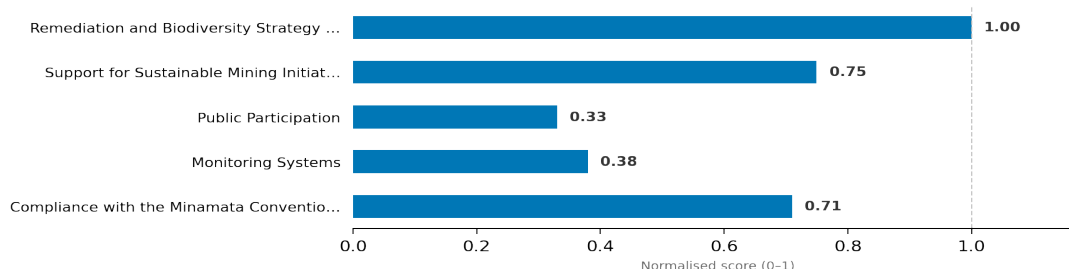
Sources

1. Suriname MinaMata initial assessMent. Minamata Convention. URL: https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/minamata_initial_assessment/Suriname-MIA-2020.pdf
2. SURINAME. OAS. URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

II. Mining policies

3.17 / 5.00

Category scores



F. Compliance with the Minamata Convention on Mercury

Score: 0.71 / 1.00

Is the country a signatory or Party to the Minamata Convention on Mercury?

1.0

Criterion 23

Justification

Yes. Suriname is a Party to the Minamata Convention on Mercury. By acceding to the Convention, Suriname is legally bound to implement its provisions aimed at protecting human health and the environment from anthropogenic emissions and releases of mercury, including obligations related to artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM), which is particularly relevant in Suriname.

Sources

<https://minamataconvention.org/en/parties/sur>

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/publications/minamata-initial-assessment-suriname>

Has the country ratified the Minamata Convention?

1.0

Criterion 24

Justification

Yes, Suriname ratified the Minamata Convention on Mercury on August 2, 2018, becoming the 95th party to the treaty, which aims to protect human health and the environment from mercury emissions. The National Assembly approved the ratification in March 2018 following efforts to address high mercury usage in small-scale gold mining.

Sources

<https://minamataconvention.org/en/parties/sur>

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/publications/minamata-initial-assessment-suriname>

Has the country submitted an initial assessment report as part of its participation in the Convention?

1.0

Criterion 25

Justification

Yes, Suriname has submitted a Minamata Initial Assessment (MIA) report as part of its participation in the Minamata Convention on Mercury. Through Global Environment Facility (GEF) enabling activities (Project GEF 00095987), Suriname conducted the project and published the Minamata Initial Assessment Report. The project initiated in October 2017 to help the country meet the obligations of the Minamata Convention. The report describes the current situation of mercury releases, awareness programs, and a roadmap for phasing out mercury use, focusing on artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM)

Sources

<https://minamataconvention.org/en/parties/sur>

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/publications/minamata-initial-assessment-suriname>

Has the country developed and submitted a National Action Plan (NAP) on mercury in accordance with the Convention?

1.0

Criterion 26

Justification

Yes, Suriname has developed and submitted its First National Action Plan (NAP) on mercury for artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM) to the Minamata Convention Secretariat in accordance with Article 7 of the Convention. The document was formally validated in late 2023 to address mercury pollution in the mining sector. The NAP focuses on promoting mercury-free technologies and reducing, where possible eliminating, the use of mercury in ASGM, which is crucial for reducing health and environmental impacts. The strategy includes a 30% reduction of mercury output from ASGM operations by 2032, along with strengthening legal and institutional frameworks. Key actions include improving awareness, improving data collection, implementing health programs, and supporting formalization within the mining sector.

Sources

<https://www.emsags.org/en/news/post/national-action-plan-validation-session/#:~:text=The%20validation%20session%20of%20the,reductions%20in%20its%20ASGM%20sector.>

<https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/NAP-Suriname-2020.pdf>

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Does the NAP explicitly mention forests or forest ecosystems in the context of mercury reduction strategies?

1.0

Criterion 27

Justification

Yes, Suriname's First National Action Plan (NAP) on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) explicitly addresses forests and forest ecosystems as a central component of its mercury reduction and environmental protection strategies. The NAP recognizes that gold mining is a leading cause of deforestation in Suriname and integrates forest-related goals into its broader mercury-free transition. The NAP is closely aligned with the EMSAGS project (Improving Environmental Management in the Mining Sector of Suriname), which specifically aims to reduce negative impacts on biodiversity and forests. The plan uses forest degradation and forest carbon stocks as key environmental indicators to assess the success of mercury reduction and the overall impact of mining operations on ecosystem services. The NAP is designed to be a "living document" that adapts to new insights, ensuring that as mercury use is phased out, the protection of Suriname's 93% forest cover remains a priority.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://emsags.org/media/yszg3k5z/final-tsa-report-asgm-in-suriname.pdf>

<https://www.wwfguianas.org/?388170/One-step-closer-to-mercury-free-gold-mining-in-Suriname>

Does the NAP specifically refer to the Amazon region in its analysis, objectives, or proposed actions?

0.0

Criterion 28

Justification

No, Suriname's National Action Plan (NAP) does not specifically address the Amazon region, it does frame the country as a critical part of the Guiana Shield. The NAP identifies Suriname's mining activity as part of the sensitive Guiana Shield ecosystem.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

Does the NAP take into account intersectional approaches?

0.0

Criterion 29

Justification

Suriname's National Action Plan (NAP) for Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) mainly mentions public health vulnerabilities specifically for women and Indigenous and Tribal peoples. The NAP and its supporting projects (like planetGOLD and EMSAGS) address the overlapping identities of miners and affected communities. However, it prioritizes mercury reduction through a technical and regulatory approach for the implementation rather than specific vulnerabilities of gender and health.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://www.emsags.org/en/the-project/>

<https://www.planetgold.org/suriname>

G. Monitoring Systems

Score: 0.38 / 1.00

Are there government-led monitoring systems for environmental and social impacts of ASM?

0.5

Criterion 30

Justification

Suriname has established some government-led monitoring systems for environmental and social impacts of ASM, but these systems are characterized by significant weaknesses in implementation and enforcement. The National Environmental Authority (NMA), previously known as the National Institute for Environment and Development in Suriname (NIMOS), serves as the primary environmental authority and has developed Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) guidelines that cover mining activities. The Ordering Goudsector (OGS) commission was established specifically to oversee the small-scale gold mining sector and manage conflicts, representing a dedicated monitoring mechanism for ASM. The Mining Decree of 1986 includes provisions for environmental compliance and reporting requirements. Despite these institutional frameworks, the 2017 IGF assessment highlighted significant challenges with weak institutional capacity, limited resources for monitoring and inspection, and inadequate enforcement of existing regulations. The remoteness of many mining areas further complicates effective monitoring efforts.

Sources

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/nma-zet-mer-in-actie-training-voor-scherpere-vergunningsvoorwaarden-en-effectieve-monitoring>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/milieu-klacht-doorgeven>

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

<https://gov.sr/thema/ordening-goudsector-ogs/>

<https://surinamenieuwscentrale.com/ordening-kleinschalige-goudsector-heeft-nog-lange-weg-te-gaan>

Is satellite or geospatial monitoring used to detect illegal or unlicensed ASM activities?

1.0

Criterion 31

Justification

Suriname has begun utilizing satellite and geospatial monitoring technologies to detect ASM activities, but this is not yet a systematic, government-led program that is being conducted on a regular basis. A significant development occurred in 2024 when the Global Partnership for Sustainable Development Data, in collaboration with the Government of Suriname, conducted a pilot study using Earth Observation (EO) and machine learning techniques to monitor environmental impacts of gold mining. This study revealed a 47% increase in ASGM activities between 2019 and 2022, leading to significant environmental degradation including 24.56 square kilometers of rainforest loss. The government has shown interest in developing these capabilities, with over 30 public servants from 12 organizations trained in EO and data analysis techniques. However, this appears to be an emerging capability rather than an established, routine monitoring system. The research indicates that while the technology and initial capacity exist, there is no evidence of systematic quarterly or annual monitoring programs specifically targeting illegal or unlicensed ASM activities.

Sources

•Global Partnership for Sustainable Development Data (2024). *Data to Monitor Environmental Impacts in Suriname*:

<https://www.data4sdgs.org/resources/data-monitor-environmental-impacts-suriname>

•Data for SDGs Blog (Nov 2024). *Mapping the big picture: Using earth observations to monitor environmental impact of gold mining*:

<https://www.data4sdgs.org/blog/mapping-big-picture-using-earth-observations-monitor-environmental-impact-gold-mining-0>

Can governmental satellite monitoring systems distinguish between artisanal, semi-mechanized, and mechanized mining activities?

0.0

Criterion 32

Justification

Based on the available research, there is no evidence that Suriname's current satellite monitoring systems can distinguish between different types of mining activities (artisanal, semi-mechanized, and mechanized). While the 2024 pilot study demonstrated the ability to detect and monitor ASGM activities using Earth Observation technology and machine learning, the documentation does not indicate that the system can differentiate between various scales and types of mining operations. The research focused on detecting land cover changes and environmental impacts rather than classifying mining activities by their operational characteristics. This represents a significant limitation in monitoring capabilities, as different types of mining operations have varying environmental and social impacts and may require different regulatory approaches. The development of such differentiation capabilities would require more sophisticated analysis techniques and potentially higher resolution satellite imagery combined with ground-truthing data.

Sources

•Global Partnership for Sustainable Development Data (2024). *Data to Monitor Environmental Impacts in Suriname*:

<https://www.data4sdgs.org/resources/data-monitor-environmental-impacts-suriname>

•No evidence found of systems capable of distinguishing mining types in available research

Is mercury concentration measured by the government in potentially affected water bodies, the food chain and/or populations?

0.0

Criterion 33

Justification

There is no evidence that the Surinamese government systematically measures mercury concentrations in water bodies, food chains, or human populations potentially affected by ASGM activities. This significant gap in environmental and public health monitoring is particularly concerning given the widespread use of mercury in artisanal gold mining operations throughout the country. While Suriname did ratify the Minamata Convention in 2018, there is no evidence of subsequent implementation of systematic mercury monitoring programs. Recent initiatives in 2024-2025 by the NMA have focused on reducing mercury use, but these do not appear to include comprehensive monitoring programs.

Sources

IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017):

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

Minamata Convention ratification status: Confirmed in 2017

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/nma-geeft-verloping-resultaat-over-onderzoek-kwikdampuitstoot-goudbedrijven>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/regionale-conferentie-belicht-duurzame-alternatieven-voor-kwikgebruik-in-kleinschalige-goudmijnbouw>

H. Public Participation

Score: 0.33 / 1.00

Are there legal channels for civil society oversight or participation in monitoring and enforcement?

0.0

Criterion 34

Justification

Suriname provides limited legal channels for civil society oversight and participation in mining monitoring and enforcement. The Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) guidelines include provisions for public consultation during the environmental assessment process, which represents a formal mechanism for public input. However, the overall legal framework for mining governance does not provide robust opportunities for ongoing civil society oversight of mining operations. The lack of constitutional recognition of Indigenous and Tribal land rights significantly limits the ability of these communities, who are often most directly affected by mining activities, to participate meaningfully in decision-making processes. The 2017 IGF assessment noted challenges with weak institutional frameworks and limited transparency, which further constrain effective civil society participation. While some consultation mechanisms exist, they appear to be primarily procedural rather than providing substantive opportunities for civil society to influence mining governance and enforcement activities.

Sources

•IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017):

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

•Environmental Assessment Guidelines Volume II – Mining (2005): Referenced in IGF report

•Constitutional provisions on Indigenous rights: Limited recognition noted in various reports

Is there an official, accessible, safe, and functional channel for individuals or communities to file complaints related to ASGM activities or associated environmental impacts?

0.0

Criterion 35

Justification

The research found no evidence of an official, accessible, safe, and functional channel specifically designed for individuals or communities to file complaints related to ASGM activities or associated environmental impacts. While the Ordening Goudsector (OGS) commission was established to manage conflicts in the ASM sector, the available documentation does not clearly indicate that this body operates as a formal complaint mechanism accessible to affected communities. The absence of such a dedicated channel represents a significant gap in governance, particularly given the widespread environmental and social impacts of ASGM activities documented throughout Suriname. Without accessible complaint mechanisms, affected communities have limited recourse when facing negative impacts from mining operations, which undermines both environmental protection and social justice objectives. The establishment of such a mechanism would be an important step toward improving mining governance and ensuring that community concerns are properly addressed.

Sources

- *IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017):*
<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>
- *No evidence of dedicated complaint mechanisms found in available research*
- *OGS commission referenced but specific complaint procedures not documented*

Are there processes for public consultation with affected communities in mining-related decisions?

0.0

Criterion 36

Justification

In Suriname Indigenous and Maroon communities are the primary victims of the environmental and territorial crimes derived from illegal mining (e.g., land encroachment, mercury pollution). There is currently no legislation recognizing collective land rights for Indigenous and tribal peoples in Suriname. This means communities often cannot legally claim to be "victims" of land invasion in a way that triggers immediate police protection or eviction of miners. While the traditional 1986 Mining Decree did not require community consultation, new environmental laws and international pressures have established formal mechanisms. Processes for public consultation in mining decisions are currently undergoing a major transition from informal guidelines to legally mandated requirements. The Environmental Framework Act now mandates public participation as part of the Environmental and Social Impact Assessment (ESIA) process. In late 2025, new regulations explicitly obligated mining applicants to consult with communities according to FPIC principles if a project is within or adjacent to their habitats, however this is not institutionalized as yet.

Sources

- <https://news.mongabay.com/2022/09/can-two-new-bills-reshape-indigenous-rights-and-illegal-gold-mining-in-suriname/>
- <https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwhuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>
- https://www.dna.sr/media/fadiptr/s-b-2024_no-56_wet_van_21_mei_2024_houdende_wijziging_van_de_milieu_raamwet_s-b-2020_no-97_.pdf
- <https://www.undp.org/suriname/news/indigenous-communities-and-government-renew-commitment-through-fpic-protocol>
- <https://eiti.org/countries/suriname>

Are civil society complaints taken into account in the authorization or assessment processes of mining projects?

0.5

Criterion 37

Justification

Because Suriname does not legally recognize collective land rights for Indigenous and tribal peoples, complaints based on "territorial violation" are often dismissed. A community can complain about pollution (an environmental crime), but they often cannot legally block a permit simply because it overlaps with their ancestral land. The formal ESIA and complaint processes generally apply to large multinational projects (like Newmont or Rosebel). The thousands of small-scale gold miners often operate with "porknocker" permits or illegally, bypassing the public consultation phase entirely. Civil society complaints are formally taken into account during the authorization and assessment phases, primarily through the environmental review process. However, in practice, the weight of these complaints is often limited by the lack of recognized land rights and weak enforcement for small-scale operations. For ongoing issues or violations by authorized (or unauthorized) miners, the government has established a direct reporting channel. Citizens and organizations can lodge complaints about pollution (e.g., mercury dumping, turbidity) directly to the NMA via a dedicated WhatsApp complaint line or an online form. An important role that civil society has is by having a formal seat at the table through the EITI Multi-Stakeholder Group (MSG). This body allows civil society representatives to review government and company data regarding mining revenues and licenses. While this doesn't stop a specific mine from being built, it provides a platform for CSOs to raise high-level complaints about corruption, lack of contract transparency, or the mismanagement of mining revenues, which can pressure the government to reform authorization protocols.

Sources

<https://news.mongabay.com/2022/09/can-two-new-bills-reshape-indigenous-rights-and-illegal-gold-mining-in-suriname/>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/nma-besprekt-gda-richtlijnen-en-taken-autoriteit-met-maatschappelijke-ngos>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/milieu-klacht-doorgeven>

<https://eitiburiname.gov.sr/en/news/statement-on-incident-on-behalf-of-the-civil-society-msg-members-eitisr/>

Do national programs on ASM include specific measures to support the participation of women, Indigenous peoples, or traditional communities?

1.0

Criterion 38

Justification

Yes, national programs—specifically the National Action Plan (NAP) for Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) and the EMSAGS Project—include specific measures to support women and Indigenous/Tribal peoples. However, these measures often focus on consultation, social welfare, and alternative livelihoods rather than direct participation in mining ownership or titles. The lack of legally recognized collective land rights remains a structural barrier to full participation for Indigenous and Tribal communities.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/news/emsags-project-promotes-gender-equality-and-sustainable-mining-paamaka-suriname>

Are there protocols for the care and protection of victims and witnesses of crimes related to or derived from illegal mining? *0.5 may be given in cases there are general protection of witnesses and victims programs, but not specific for illegal mining

0.5

Criterion 39

Justification

There are no specific, standalone protocols exclusively dedicated to the care and protection of victims and witnesses of illegal mining crimes in Suriname. Instead, protection is fragmented and largely relies on the frameworks designed for Human Trafficking (TIP) or general criminal law. Because illegal mining is often inextricably linked to other crimes—such as sex trafficking, labor exploitation, and money laundering—victims are typically processed through those respective legal channels rather than a mining-specific system. The government body responsible for “ordering” the gold sector focuses on regulation, taxation, and removing illegal miners. It does not have a mandate or budget for social services or victim care. Also, there are no specific medical protocols for treating victims of mercury poisoning caused by illegal mining. Public health responses are limited to awareness campaigns (e.g., by the Medical Mission) rather than established clinical care pathways for heavy metal toxicity.

Sources

<https://2021-2025.state.gov/reports/2024-trafficking-in-persons-report/suriname>

<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

<https://gov.sr/thema/ordering-goudsector-ogs/>

I. Support for Sustainable Mining Initiatives

Score: 0.75 / 1.00

Are there public programs to support formalization through incentives to and capacity-building of ASM gold miners?

1.0

Criterion 40

Justification

The Surinamese government provides limited technical assistance and capacity-building programs for ASM, primarily through international partnerships. The most significant initiative is the World Bank's Competitiveness and Sector Diversification Project, launched in 2019, which includes a substantial component dedicated to strengthening mining sector governance, transparency, and administration. This project provides technical assistance for regulatory reforms and capacity building for the Ministry of Natural Resources (Min NH) and the Ministry of Trade, Industry & Tourism (Min EZOTI). Two current ongoing initiatives are the, "Improving Environmental Management in the Mining Sector of Suriname, with Emphasis on Artisanal and Small-Scale Gold" (EMSAGS) Project and the "GEF GOLD+: Advancing formalization and mercury-free gold in Suriname", also referred to as Planetgold. These projects focus on the formalization of small-scale gold mining and the phasing out of mercury, which are crucial for environmental sustainability and the health of the mining community. The GEF GOLD project is particularly significant as it aims to address the environmental impacts of gold mining and promote sustainable practices in the sector. Additionally, recent capacity-building efforts have focused on Earth Observation and data analysis techniques, with over 30 public servants trained in these skills. However, these initiatives appear to be project-based and internationally supported rather than representing a systematic, government-led program for ASM technical assistance and capacity building.

Sources

<https://emsags.org/>

<https://www.planetgold.org/suriname>

<https://documents.worldbank.org/en/publication/documents-reports/documentdetail/246651562983310225>

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

<https://www.data4sdgs.org/resources/data-monitor-environmental-impacts-suriname>

Are there accessible financing mechanisms promoted by the State to support sustainable practices as an alternative to unsustainable ASM gold mining?

1.0

Criterion 41

Justification

Suriname has established some mechanisms aimed at ASM formalization, but these efforts are limited in scope and effectiveness. The primary initiative is the Ordering Goudsector (OGS) commission, established to oversee the small-scale gold mining sector and manage conflicts between different stakeholders. This represents a step toward bringing the ASM sector under formal regulatory oversight. The National Development Plan 2021-2026 acknowledges the environmental risks of unstructured ASGM and emphasizes the need for formalization, explicitly noting that "formalization and legality are two different concepts that need to be clarified and well understood." However, the 2017 IGF assessment noted that the ASM sector remains largely informal, indicating that existing formalization efforts have had limited success. The government has also expressed plans to establish a "Delfstoffen Instituut Suriname" (DIS) or Minerals Institute to improve governance and oversight, which could support formalization efforts, but this initiative appears to still be in planning stages.

Sources

IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017):

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

National Development Plan 2021-2026: Referenced in SESA report RINA Consulting Inc. (January 2023). *Strategic Environmental and Social Assessment (SESA):*

<https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Scoping-Report-FINAL-Incl-Appendix.pdf>

Are safer mercury-free technologies promoted through incentives or support programs?

1.0

Criterion 42

Justification

The Surinamese government has recently begun supporting initiatives to promote mercury-free mining technologies, but these efforts are still in early stages and not yet part of a comprehensive national strategy. Significant developments occurred in late 2024 and 2025, including the launch of new initiatives to reduce mercury use and participation in regional conferences focused on sustainable alternatives to mercury in ASGM. In November 2024, Suriname launched a new initiative specifically aimed at reducing mercury use in mining operations. In July 2025, the EMSAGS Project and WWF-Guianas hosted a regional conference on sustainable alternatives to mercury use in artisanal and small-scale gold mining, indicating growing regional cooperation on this issue. Suriname's ratification of the Minamata Convention on Mercury in 2017 also demonstrates commitment to addressing mercury use. However, these are relatively recent developments, and there is limited evidence of systematic, long-term government programs to promote mercury-free technologies or provide technical and financial support for miners to transition to alternative methods.

Sources

• *Caribbean Today (Nov 2024). Suriname Launches New Initiative to Reduce Mercury Use:*

<https://www.caribbeantoday.com/sections/environment/suriname-launches-new-initiative-to-reduce-mercury-use>

• *WWF (Jul 2025). The EMSAGS Project and WWF-Guianas Host Regional Conference on Sustainable Alternatives to Mercury Use:*

<https://www.wwf.org.ec/?396193/The-EMSAGS-Project-and-WWF-Guianas-Host-Regional-Conference-on-Sustainable-Alternatives-to-Mercury-Use-in-Artisanal-and-Small-Scale-Gold-Mining>

• *Minamata Convention ratification (2017): Confirmed in multiple sources*

Are women, traditional communities and Indigenous peoples specifically included in sustainable ASM initiatives?

1.0

Criterion 43

Justification

The EMSAGS project Actively works on gender assessments to understand how mining policies impact men and women differently in districts like Brokopondo and Sipaliwini. Women make up a smaller percentage of the direct mining workforce (est. 15–20%), they are centrally involved in the "service economy" surrounding mines (cooking, camps, trading). The NAP highlights that women face unique risks, including exposure to mercury in domestic settings (burning amalgam at home) and economic dependency that makes them less able to negotiate safer working conditions. It also proposes strategies to include gender-mainstreaming in formalization processes to ensure women can hold mining titles and access financing, preventing them from being sidelined by formalization that privileges male equipment owners. In addition, does the planetGOLD Suriname project explicitly track gender metrics (aiming for ~50% female beneficiaries in knowledge sharing) and focuses on responsible supply chains that account for the social welfare of marginalized community members. However, ASGM activities in Suriname occur almost exclusively in the interior, on lands traditionally inhabited by Indigenous and Maroon (Tribal) communities which are formally not recognized by the government. The NAP process (and the EMSAGS project) emphasize Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC) and recognizes that these communities are "doubly" affected—both as participants in mining (for economic survival) and as victims of the resulting environmental degradation (mercury in fish, their primary protein source). Although this is emphasized, there is weak implementation of the FPIC process.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://www.emsags.org/en/the-project/>

<https://www.planetgold.org/suriname>

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/news/effectively-managing-gold-mining-suriname>

Are there governmental programs to collaborate with NGOs, academic institutions, or international agencies to promote sustainable ASM practices?

1.0

Criterion 44

Justification

Yes, the Government of Suriname actively collaborates with various stakeholders through several major programs to promote sustainable Artisanal and Small-Scale Mining (ASM). These initiatives primarily focus on phasing out mercury, formalizing the sector, and introducing environmentally responsible mining technologies. Two current programs facilitating these collaborations are EMSAGS and planetGOLD Suriname. Both are implemented in partnership with the Ministry of Natural Resources (MNR) and the National Institute for Environment and Development in Suriname (NIMOS), currently transformed to the National Environmental Authority (NMA). International agencies such as the UNDP, GEF and the IDB provide funding, technical oversight in alignment with global standards such as the Minamata convention. Academic institutions such as the Anton de Kom University, in particular the Geology and Mining Department facilitates knowledge exchange and student internships focused on sustainable development. Also, the Center for Agricultural Research in Suriname researches the rehabilitation of mined-out lands, often in coordination with government environmental mandates.

Sources

<https://www.emsags.org/en/the-project/>

<https://www.planetgold.org/suriname>

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/news/effectively-managing-gold-mining-suriname>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/nma-besprekt-gda-richtlijnen-en-taken-autoriteit-met-maatschappelijke-ngos>

Are there clear protection mechanisms for individuals working in areas of mining?

0.0

Criterion 45

Justification

Suriname lacks clear protection mechanisms for individuals working in mining areas, leaving workers vulnerable to various forms of violence, exploitation, and unsafe working conditions. This absence of protection is particularly problematic given the documented presence of criminal organizations and violence in mining zones. The informal nature of much of the ASM sector means that many workers operate outside the formal labor law framework and are not covered by standard worker protection mechanisms. The OAS report documents the involvement of criminal groups in mining operations, creating dangerous working environments where workers may face threats, violence, or exploitation without recourse to effective protection. The remote location of many mining areas compounds the protection challenges. Limited state presence in these regions means that workers cannot rely on timely intervention by security forces when threats arise. The vast and often inaccessible nature of mining zones makes it difficult for authorities to monitor working conditions or respond to incidents. The lack of formal employment relationships in much of the ASM sector means that workers often lack access to social protection systems, health insurance, or other safety nets that might provide some measure of security. Many workers are migrants or operate on informal arrangements that provide no legal protections. Environmental hazards, including mercury exposure and unsafe mining practices, create additional risks for workers. The absence of comprehensive health and safety regulations specific to ASM operations, combined with limited enforcement capacity, means that workers often face dangerous conditions without adequate protection. The involvement of organized crime in mining operations creates particular risks for workers who might witness illegal activities or who might be coerced into participating in criminal enterprises. Without clear protection mechanisms, workers have little recourse when facing such situations.

Sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case* (March 2023). URL:

<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

- No evidence of specific worker protection mechanisms found in comprehensive research

Is there recognition or promotion of international certification schemes by the government?

1.0

Criterion 46

Justification

Yes, the government of Suriname recognizes and promotes international certification schemes and standards for sustainable mining, primarily focusing on mercury reduction in artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM) and environmental management, largely through partnerships with international organizations and initiatives. The government of Suriname acceded to the Minamata Convention on Mercury in 2018 and is working with the UN Development Programme (UNDP) and the Global Environment Facility (GEF) to implement its National Action Plan (NAP) to reduce and eliminate mercury use in the ASGM sector. Also, Suriname is an EITI-implementing country, promoting transparency in reporting on environmental, social, and economic impacts of mining, including future oil and gas revenues.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://eiti.org/countries/suriname>

https://redd.unfccc.int/files/2018_frel_submission_suriname.pdf

Is there a government incentive for the adoption of gold certification?

0.0

Criterion 47

Justification

There are no documented government incentives for the adoption of gold certification in Suriname. The research conducted across government websites, policy documents, and international assessments found no evidence of tax incentives, preferential treatment, financial support, or other mechanisms to encourage miners to pursue certification for responsible gold production. The Mining Decree of 1986 and subsequent regulations do not include provisions for incentivizing certification schemes. The absence of such incentives, combined with the lack of recognition of international certification schemes, creates a policy environment that does not encourage responsible mining practices or participation in certified supply chains. This gap in policy represents a missed opportunity to drive improvements in environmental and social performance in the ASM sector through market-based mechanisms.

Sources

- *Mining Decree 1986 (Suriname): Available through government legal databases*
- *IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017):*
<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>
- *No specific government incentive programs found in research*

J. Remediation and Biodiversity Strategy Integration

Score: 1.00 / 1.00

Is ASM gold mining recognized in the country's National Biodiversity Strategy and Action Plan (NBSAP)?

1.0

Criterion 48

Justification

Yes, the updated National Biodiversity Strategy and Action Plan (NBSAP) for 2024-2035 aligns with the need to tackle land degradation and habitat loss, of which ASGM is a major contributor. The NBSAP identifies small-scale gold mining in southeastern Suriname as a primary driver for biodiversity loss, irreversible changes to ecosystems, and contamination of water systems via heavy metals.

Sources

- https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Suriname-Aligned-NAP-Final-Dec-14-2023_DN_edit_PRINT_signed.pdf
<https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/DOCUMENTS-UPDATED-NBSAP-2024-2035-NBAP-2024-2030.pdf>

Does the country have specific programs, targets, or funding mechanisms for ecosystem restoration in areas affected by ASM gold mining?

1.0

Criterion 49

Justification

Yes, Suriname has several specific programs and is currently developing dedicated funding mechanisms to address ecosystem restoration and environmental management in areas affected by Artisanal and Small-scale Gold Mining (ASGM). The Improving Environmental Management in the Mining Sector of Suriname (EMSAGS) project is a flagship initiative funded by the Global Environment Facility (GEF) and implemented by the UNDP. This project focuses on reducing the negative effects of ASGM on biodiversity, forests, and water. This is done by disseminating environmentally responsible mining technologies and methods, and developing mechanisms to address impacts across the entire mine life cycle. Another project is the planetGOLD Suriname (GEF GOLD+), which is a five year project that aims to formalize the ASGM sector and promote mercury-free technologies in key mining districts. Also,

Suriname is part of the Amazon Sustainable Landscapes Program, that works on strengthening the management of protected and productive landscapes to combat land degradation. In the NBSAP specific targets regarding ecosystem restoration are mentioned.

Sources

https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Suriname-Aligned-NAP-Final-Dec-14-2023_DN_edit_PRINT_signed.pdf

<https://gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/DOCUMENTS-UPDATED-NBSAP-2024-2035-NBAP-2024-2030.pdf>

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/national_action_plan/Suriname-NAP-2024-EN.pdf

<https://www.emsags.org/en/the-project/>

<https://www.planetgold.org/suriname>

[https://www.undp.org/suriname/projects/strengthening-management-protected-and-productive-landscapes-surinames-e-amazon#:~:text=The%20ASL2%20Suriname%20project%20\(%E2%80%9CStrengthening,and%20Forest%20Management%20\(GBB\).](https://www.undp.org/suriname/projects/strengthening-management-protected-and-productive-landscapes-surinames-e-amazon#:~:text=The%20ASL2%20Suriname%20project%20(%E2%80%9CStrengthening,and%20Forest%20Management%20(GBB).)

Are there requirements or guidance for restoration, remediation, or compensation for degraded areas?

1.0

Criterion 50

Justification

Yes, the Mining Decree of 1986 provides the basic legal structure for mining rights, restoration and compensation, however it is often cited as outdated regarding modern remediation standards. A requirement is that mining permit holders to submit quarterly reports and follow general regulations. Because the 1986 Decree is broad, the government often negotiates specific Mineral Agreements with larger companies. These agreements function as standalone laws and typically include much stricter requirements for mine closure, remediation, and financial guarantees for restoration, however this is not the case in ASGM operations. For all mining operations, The Environmental Framework ACT (2020) establishes the National Environmental Authority (NMA) and mandates that all major projects, including mining, undergo an Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA). The EIA must include specific mitigation and management plans for environmental impacts throughout the project's life cycle. Current recommendations emphasize the need for clearer liability regulations to ensure that those responsible for degradation are held accountable for clean-up. Compensation Mechanisms: While formal financial compensation for ecosystem loss is still evolving, the Environmental Fund Decree mentioned in the Environmental Framework ACT is one of the priority regulations being drafted to provide a structured way to finance the restoration of abandoned and orphaned mine sites. Therefore a score of 0.5 is assigned.

Sources

<https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwhuuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>

https://www.dna.sr/media/fadictpr/s-b-2024_no-56_wet_van_21_mei_2024_houdende_wijziging_van_de_milieu_raamwet_s-b-2020_no-97_.pdf

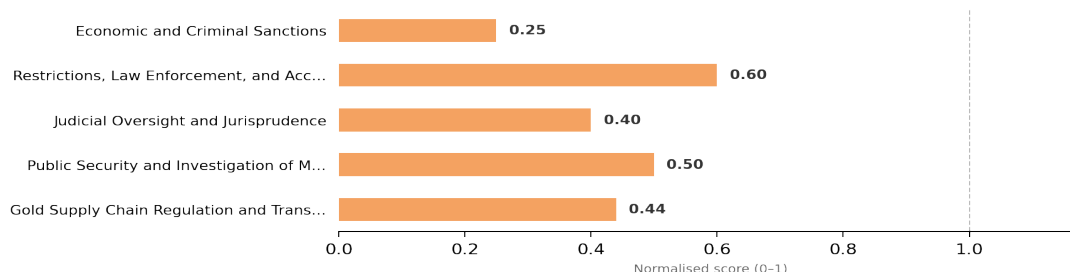
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<https://www.emsags.org/en/the-project/>

III. Investigation and enforcement

2.19 / 5.00

Category scores



K. Gold Supply Chain Regulation and Transparency

Score: 0.44 / 1.00

Does the country require formal registration of all actors in the ASM gold supply chain (miners, traders, and exporters)?

1.0

Criterion 51

Justification

Suriname has established formal registration requirements for certain actors in the gold supply chain, but these requirements do not comprehensively cover all participants, particularly in the informal ASM sector. The regulatory framework requires mining rights holders to obtain formal licenses for exploration and exploitation activities, and gold exporters must obtain special category licenses issued by the Foreign Exchange Commission. According to the 2025 EITI Suriname Report, "The license granting the right to export gold is a special category license and is issued by the Foreign Exchange Commission." This demonstrates formal registration requirements for exporters. The Surinamese legal framework recognizes five types of mining rights: reconnaissance, exploration, exploitation, small-scale mining, and quarrying of building materials, indicating a structured licensing system for miners. However, significant gaps exist in the registration framework. The OAS report notes that an estimated 50-60% of the regional mining industry operates informally, creating substantial challenges for state supervision and control. Small and medium-sized gold mining companies do not directly export their product but sell to local buyers, who then sell to licensed export companies. This intermediate layer of local buyers and traders often operates without formal registration requirements, creating a significant gap in supply chain oversight. The informal nature of much ASM activity means many individual miners and small-scale operators work without formal permits or registration. While the legal framework exists for formal registration, enforcement and compliance in the ASM sector remain limited, particularly in remote mining areas where state presence is minimal.

Sources

- EITI Suriname Report 2025. URL: https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/A-25.56_EITISR-Final-Report-150725-Final-Version.pdf
- EITI International: Suriname Country Profile. URL: <https://eti.org/countries/suriname>
- OAS Report: On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal G52Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023). URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Are there specific permits or procedures required for exporting ASM gold?

1.0

Criterion 52

Justification

Suriname has established specific permits and procedures for gold export, but these are not specifically tailored to ASM gold, creating challenges in distinguishing and tracking ASM-origin gold through the export process. The regulatory framework requires all gold exporters to obtain special category licenses from the Foreign Exchange Commission. According to the OAS report, "Conditions for granting a gold buying and export license" are established in the legal framework. All gold intended for export must be processed at the Kaloti Mint House Suriname (KMHS), which serves as the central processing facility for gold exports. However, the system lacks specific procedures for ASM gold. The 2025 EITI report notes that legal gold from various sources is often mixed in gold shops and processing facilities, making it extremely difficult to distinguish ASM gold from other sources during the export process. This mixing of gold from different sources undermines the ability to apply specific procedures or requirements to ASM gold exports. The absence of ASM-specific export procedures represents a significant gap in supply chain governance. Without the ability to distinguish ASM gold at the export stage, it becomes impossible to apply targeted due diligence, traceability requirements, or responsible sourcing standards specifically to the ASM sector. This limitation also makes it difficult to track the volume and value of ASM gold exports separately from other gold production. Royalty payments are collected from exports made by licensed companies, with fees deposited into the State's bank account at the Central Bank of Suriname (CBoS). However, since small and medium-sized miners sell to intermediaries rather than exporting directly, the royalty system does not provide direct oversight of ASM operations.

Sources

- EITI Suriname Report 2025. URL:

https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/A-25.56_EITISR-Final-Report-150725-Final-Version.pdf

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal*

Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023). URL:

<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Are files on ASM areas, including titles, licenses, embargoes, and monitored zones, available in open, updated formats compatible with geospatial analysis systems?

0.5

Criterion 53

Justification

Suriname has made significant progress in digitizing and making mining-related information publicly accessible, but the system falls short of providing comprehensive, up-to-date, and fully geospatial-compatible data for all ASM-related information. The country has established online systems for mining license applications and has improved cadastre management. The EITI Suriname website provides access to a register of mining licenses, representing a positive step toward transparency. According to the 2024 EITI validation report, "Suriname should maintain a publicly available register or cadastre system with timely and comprehensive information on mining licenses," indicating ongoing efforts to improve the system. However, significant limitations remain. The 2016 EITI report noted that "there was no systematic register at GMD [Geological Mining Service] or MONR [Ministry of Natural Resources] displaying the flow, status, or outcome of applications." While improvements have been made since 2016, the research indicates that a fully comprehensive and regularly updated system is not yet in place. The current system lacks complete integration of all relevant ASM information, including embargoes and monitored zones, in formats that are fully compatible with modern geospatial analysis systems. The absence of real-time updates and comprehensive coverage of all ASM areas represents a significant limitation for effective monitoring and enforcement. The digitization efforts are part of broader regional trends, as noted in development minerals research highlighting the importance of digital mapping for mining safety and governance.

Sources

- EITI Suriname: *Register of Mining Licenses.* URL:

https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/en/eiti-suriname-reports/eiti-suriname-report-2016/register-of_x0002_mining-licenses/

- EITI: Validation of Suriname (April 9, 2024). URL: <https://eiti.org/document/23627>
- EITI Report of the Republic of Suriname for the fiscal year 2016. URL: https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Suriname_EITI_report_2016.pdf
- Development Minerals: Digitally Mapping a Safer Future for Mining (April 17, 2024). URL: <https://developmentminerals.org/digitally-mapping-a-safer-future-for-mining/G55>

Is there a strategy in place to ensure the traceability of gold from extraction to final sale?

0.0

Criterion 54

Justification

Suriname lacks comprehensive traceability mechanisms to track gold from extraction to final sale, representing one of the most significant gaps in the country's mining governance framework. This absence of end-to-end traceability creates substantial vulnerabilities for illicit gold entering legitimate supply chains. The fundamental challenge is the widespread practice of mixing legal gold from various sources in gold shops and processing facilities. The OAS report explicitly states that "legal gold from various sources is often mixed in gold shops, making it difficult to track its origin." This mixing occurs at multiple points in the supply chain, effectively breaking any potential chain of custody that might exist. The absence of comprehensive laws governing the entire gold supply chain exacerbates traceability challenges. According to investigative research by the Global Investigative Journalism Network (GIJN), "There are no laws applicable to the whole supply chain, so certifiers are doing this job. Certifiers are industry schemes, paid for by the industry." This indicates that Suriname relies on voluntary industry schemes rather than mandatory government-enforced traceability systems. The EMSAGS project report notes that "To meet these standards, an increasing percentage of the gold sold on the international market should be traceable back to its source in Suriname." However, this statement reflects an aspiration rather than current reality, acknowledging that comprehensive traceability is not yet achieved. The lack of traceability mechanisms has serious implications for combating illegal mining and money laundering. Without the ability to track gold from mine to market, it becomes extremely difficult to distinguish legally mined gold from illegally extracted gold, facilitating the laundering of proceeds from illegal mining operations. The Security Law contains some rules on the value of processed and unprocessed gold and silver, stating that "Silver and gold can only be sold as such if their value is secured," but this does not constitute a comprehensive traceability system that tracks the physical movement and transformation of gold through the supply chain.

Sources

- OAS Report: On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023). URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
- GIJN: Investigating How Illegal Gold Gets Into the Legitimate Supply Chain (April 25, 2025). URL: <https://gijn.org/stories/investigating-illegal-gold-mining-legitimate-supply-chain/>
- EMSAGS: Final TSA Report ASGM in Suriname. URL: <https://emsags.org/media/yszg3k5z/final-tsa-report-asgm-in-suriname.pdf>
- WWF: The Gold Marketing Chain in Suriname (2010). URL: https://wwflac.awsassets.panda.org/downloads/2010_gold_mining_marketing_chain_heemskerk.pdf

Is disclosure of transactions between miners, traders, and exporters mandatory?

0.0

Criterion 55

Justification

Suriname does not have mandatory disclosure requirements for transactions between miners, traders, and exporters throughout the gold supply chain. This absence of transaction-level transparency represents a critical gap in the country's ability to monitor and regulate gold flows and detect potential illicit activities. While licensed gold exporters are required to report their exports for royalty calculation purposes to the Central Bank of Suriname (CBoS), this reporting focuses on aggregate export volumes and values rather than detailed transaction-level information that would reveal the specific sources and intermediary transactions. The 2023 Investment Climate Statement notes that

"There are no domestic transparency measures requiring the disclosure of beneficial ownership information," indicating broader limitations in transparency requirements that extend to mining sector transactions. Although Suriname became a member of the Extractive Industry Transparency Initiative (EITI) in 2017, EITI reporting focuses on aggregate payments and revenues rather than individual transaction disclosure. The informal nature of much of the ASM sector means that many transactions occur outside formal banking systems and regulatory oversight. Small and medium-sized miners typically sell their gold to local buyers in cash transactions that are not systematically recorded or reported to authorities. These local buyers then aggregate gold from multiple sources before selling to licensed exporters, creating multiple layers of transactions that are not subject to mandatory disclosure. The absence of mandatory transaction disclosure requirements facilitates money laundering and makes it extremely difficult for authorities to track suspicious financial flows or identify the ultimate sources of exported gold. This gap is particularly problematic given the documented presence of criminal organizations in Suriname's gold sector.

Sources

- US State Department: 2023 Investment Climate Statements: Suriname. URL: <https://2021-2025.state.gov/reports/2023-investment-climate-statements/suriname/>
- EITI Suriname Report 2025. URL: https://eitisuriname.gov.sr/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/A-25.56_EITISR-Final-Report-150725-Final-Version.pdf
- OAS Report: On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023). URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Does the legal framework require financial institutions to verify the legal provenance of gold-related transactions?

0.0

Criterion 56

Justification

Suriname does not have specific legal requirements for financial institutions to perform enhanced due diligence on gold-related transactions beyond standard anti-money laundering (AML) procedures. This represents a significant vulnerability in the financial system's ability to detect and prevent the laundering of proceeds from illegal gold mining. The OAS report extensively documents the challenges of money laundering in Suriname's gold sector, noting the involvement of transnational criminal organizations and the use of sophisticated financial schemes to launder illegal gold proceeds. The report highlights that "there is a chain of illicit activities that range from the irregular importation of precursors and machinery to money laundering and the involvement of criminal syndicates." The absence of sector-specific due diligence requirements means that financial institutions generally operate under a presumption of good faith regarding the legal provenance of gold-related transactions. This presumption is particularly problematic given the documented prevalence of illegal mining and the difficulty in distinguishing legal from illegal gold in the marketplace. Standard AML procedures may not be sufficient to address the specific risks associated with gold transactions, which often involve large cash payments, complex ownership structures, and cross-border movements that can obscure the true source of funds. The mixing of legal and illegal gold in the supply chain makes it extremely difficult for financial institutions to assess the legitimacy of gold-related transactions without specific guidance and requirements. The European Union's due diligence requirements for 3TG (Tin, Tungsten, Tantalum, and Gold) importers, which became operational in 2021, highlight the international trend toward enhanced due diligence for gold transactions. However, Suriname has not implemented similar domestic requirements for its financial institutions.

Sources

- OAS Report: On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023). URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
- EUR-Lex: European Commission Regulation on 3TG Due Diligence (September 24, 2024). URL: <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/PDF/?uri=CELEX:52024DC0415>

Is there a centralized digital/electronic registry for gold supply chain transactions accessible to regulatory authorities and civil society?

0.0

Criterion 57

Justification

Suriname does not have a centralized digital or electronic registry for gold supply chain transactions that is accessible to regulatory authorities and civil society. This absence represents a fundamental gap in transparency and accountability mechanisms for the gold sector. While the EITI Suriname website provides some aggregate data on gold exports and revenues, this information does not constitute a comprehensive, transaction-level registry of supply chain activities. The EITI reporting focuses on payments made by extractive companies to the government and revenues received by the government, rather than detailed supply chain transactions between private actors. The lack of a centralized registry is particularly problematic given the complex structure of Suriname's gold supply chain, where small and medium-sized miners sell to local buyers, who then sell to licensed exporters. Without a centralized system to track these transactions, it becomes impossible for regulatory authorities to monitor the flow of gold and money through the system or for civil society to conduct meaningful oversight. The absence of such a registry also limits the government's ability to implement effective anti-money laundering measures or to detect suspicious transaction patterns that might indicate illegal mining or other criminal activities. International best practices increasingly emphasize the importance of centralized, accessible registries for high-risk commodities like gold. Some progress has been made in digitizing mining license information, but this falls far short of a comprehensive supply chain transaction registry. The current systems focus on licensing and cadastral information rather than ongoing transaction monitoring and reporting.

Sources

- EITI Suriname: Official Website. URL: <https://eitipuriname.gov.sr/en/>
- No evidence of centralized transaction registry found in comprehensive research across government and international source

Are there protocols for information sharing and joint enforcement with neighboring countries?

1.0

Criterion 58

Justification

Yes, Suriname engages in regional information sharing regarding gold supply chain regulation, particularly through South-South cooperation with Guyana, focusing on Small-Scale Gold Mining (ASGM) best practices. While specific, public joint enforcement protocols are limited, Suriname works with international bodies (e.g., CARICOM) on standards and has established, via the Organization of American States, mechanisms for addressing illegal gold mining finances. Also, The FIU Suriname works on anti-money laundering measures that involve reporting on cross-border movement of valuable items, aligning with regional financial action task forces. Also, Suriname engages with INTERPOL to tackle cross-border environmental crimes, including illegal timber exploitation and wildlife trafficking, with a strong focus on activities in tri-border regions. It also partners with international organizations such as the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) to enhance cooperation in the investigation and prosecution of environmental offenses, frequently working alongside the Directorate of National Security.

Sources

- <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
- <https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2026/198-arrests-in-cross-border-illegal-gold-mining-operation-in-South-America>
- https://international-partnerships.ec.europa.eu/policies/programming/programmes/el-paccto-20_en
- <https://www.emsags.org/en/news/post/knowledge-sharing-and-exchange-suriname-guyana-on-small-scale-gold-mining>
- <https://fiusuriname.org/Publicaties/cfatf-4meval-suriname.pdf>

Do public security bodies have specific strategies in place for safeguarding Indigenous and traditional communities against crimes related to mining in their territories?

0.0

Criterion 59

Justification

There is no evidence that Suriname's public security bodies have developed specific strategies to safeguard Indigenous communities against crimes related to mining in their territories. This represents a critical gap in protection mechanisms, particularly given the documented vulnerability of Indigenous communities to mining-related violence and environmental crimes. The OAS report extensively documents the presence of criminal groups and associated violence in mining areas, noting that these activities "disproportionately affect Indigenous communities" who often live in or near mining zones. The report highlights the involvement of transnational criminal organizations in illegal mining operations, which creates significant security risks for Indigenous populations. The lack of constitutional recognition of Indigenous land rights in Suriname exacerbates this vulnerability. Without formal recognition of their territorial rights, Indigenous communities have limited legal standing to exclude mining operations from their traditional territories or to seek protection from mining-related crimes. The remote location of many Indigenous territories and mining areas creates additional challenges for providing effective protection. The limited presence of state security forces in these areas means that Indigenous communities are often left to face mining-related threats without adequate support from public security bodies. The absence of specific protection strategies is particularly concerning given documented cases of violence, intimidation, and environmental destruction associated with illegal mining operations. Indigenous communities often face threats when they attempt to resist or report illegal mining activities in their territories. International human rights standards emphasize the state's obligation to provide special protection for Indigenous peoples, particularly in contexts where they face heightened risks from extractive activities. Suriname's failure to develop specific strategies for protecting Indigenous communities from mining-related crimes represents a significant gap in meeting these obligations.

Sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case* (March 2023). URL:

<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

- No evidence of specific Indigenous protection strategies found in comprehensive research

Are there specialized police and prosecutor units for environmental crimes or illegal mining with effective coverage in critical areas?

1.0

Criterion 60

Justification

Suriname has established some specialized units to address illegal mining and environmental crimes, but their effectiveness is significantly limited by resource constraints, institutional capacity gaps, and the challenging geography of mining areas. The country has created the Ordening Goudsector (OGS) commission specifically to oversee the small-scale gold mining sector and manage conflicts between different stakeholders. This represents a dedicated institutional mechanism for addressing ASM-related issues, including illegal mining activities. Police forces do conduct operations against illegal mining, and there are some specialized capabilities within law enforcement agencies. However, the OAS report notes that while efforts exist to combat illegal mining, "a more specialized and coordinated approach is needed" to effectively address the scale and complexity of the challenges. The effectiveness of these specialized units is severely constrained by several factors. The vast and remote nature of mining areas makes it extremely difficult to maintain effective coverage of critical zones. Many mining operations occur in areas that are accessible only by boat or aircraft, requiring significant resources for effective monitoring and enforcement. Resource limitations represent a major constraint on the effectiveness of specialized units. The OAS report highlights the need

for enhanced institutional capacity and resources to effectively combat illegal mining and associated criminal activities. Limited budgets, equipment, and personnel restrict the ability of specialized units to maintain a meaningful presence in critical mining areas. The involvement of well-organized criminal groups with significant resources creates additional challenges for law enforcement. These groups often have better equipment and local knowledge than government forces, making enforcement operations particularly difficult and dangerous. Coordination between different agencies and levels of government remains a challenge, limiting the effectiveness of specialized units that must work across institutional boundaries to address complex mining-related crimes.

Sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case* (March 2023). URL:
<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>
<https://gov.sr/thema/ordering-goudsector-ogs/>
<https://surinamenieuwscentrale.com/ordering-kleinschalige-goudsector-heeft-nog-lange-weg-te-gaan>

Is there a clear procedure for investigating crimes related to mining?

0.0

Criterion 61

Justification

While Suriname has general procedures for criminal investigation, there is limited evidence of clear, specialized procedures specifically designed for investigating the complex crimes associated with mining operations. This represents a significant gap given the unique characteristics of mining-related crimes, which often involve environmental damage, financial crimes, human rights abuses, and transnational criminal organizations. Mining-related crimes typically require specialized investigative approaches that differ from conventional criminal investigations. These crimes often involve complex financial schemes, environmental evidence that requires technical expertise to collect and analyze, and cross-border elements that require international cooperation. The absence of specialized procedures can significantly hamper the effectiveness of investigations. The OAS report recommends strengthening investigative capabilities and developing more specialized approaches to combat illegal mining and associated criminal activities. This recommendation suggests that current procedures are inadequate for addressing the full scope of mining-related crimes. The complexity of mining-related crimes often requires coordination between multiple agencies, including environmental authorities, financial intelligence units, mining regulators, and traditional law enforcement. Without clear procedures for inter-agency coordination and information sharing, investigations may be fragmented and ineffective. Environmental crimes associated with mining often require specialized technical expertise to document and prosecute effectively. The collection and analysis of environmental evidence, assessment of ecological damage, and establishment of causal links between mining activities and environmental harm require specialized knowledge and procedures that may not be available in general criminal investigation frameworks. The transnational nature of many mining-related crimes, including money laundering and the involvement of international criminal organizations, requires procedures for international cooperation and mutual legal assistance that may not be well-developed in the context of mining crimes.

Sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case* (March 2023). URL:
<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Does the country have bilateral or multilateral protocols or agreements in place to coordinate joint police operations for the enforcement of environmental and mining laws?

1.0

Criterion 62

Justification

Yes, Suriname has established both bilateral and multilateral protocols and agreements to coordinate joint actions for the enforcement of environmental and mining laws, largely focused on controlling illegal mining, deforestation and

cross-border environmental crimes. Suriname ratified the Minamata Convention on Mercury in 2018 to address the importation, trade, and use of mercury, particularly within the artisanal and small-scale gold mining (ASGM) sector. Suriname collaborates through INTERPOL to combat transnational environmental crimes, including illegal timber and wildlife trade, particularly in tri-border areas and works with international partners such as the UNODC (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime) to strengthen partnerships for investigating and prosecuting environmental crimes, often involving the Directorate of National Security.

Sources

<https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2026/198-arrests-in-cross-border-illegal-gold-mining-operation-in-South-America>

https://international-partnerships.ec.europa.eu/policies/programming/programmes/el-paccto-20_en

M. Judicial Oversight and Jurisprudence

Score: 0.40 / 1.00

Have courts issued binding decisions related to illegal gold mining or its socio-environmental impacts in the last five years?

0.0

Criterion 63

Justification

Comprehensive research across available sources found no evidence of binding court decisions in Suriname related to illegal gold mining or its socio-environmental impacts in the past five years. This absence of judicial engagement represents a significant gap in the legal system's response to documented mining-related crimes and environmental damage. The lack of publicly available information about court decisions in mining-related cases suggests either that few such cases have been brought before the courts, that cases have not resulted in binding decisions, or that judicial decisions are not systematically documented and made publicly accessible. Any of these scenarios represents a weakness in the judicial system's role in mining governance. Given the extensive documentation of illegal mining activities, environmental damage, and associated criminal enterprises in Suriname, the absence of binding court decisions is particularly concerning. The OAS report extensively documents illegal mining operations and associated crimes, yet there is no evidence that these activities have resulted in significant judicial action. The weak enforcement of mining regulations and environmental laws, as documented in various assessments, may contribute to the lack of court cases. If regulatory agencies are not effectively detecting and prosecuting violations, fewer cases will reach the courts for adjudication. The complexity of mining-related cases, which often involve technical environmental evidence and complex financial crimes, may create barriers to successful prosecution. Without specialized judicial capacity to handle such cases, prosecutors may be reluctant to bring cases that are unlikely to result in convictions. The absence of binding court decisions also means that Suriname lacks judicial precedents that could guide future enforcement efforts and clarify legal standards for mining-related crimes and environmental violations.

Sources

- No evidence of binding court decisions found in comprehensive research across government, legal, and international sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case* (March 2023). URL:

<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Have judicial decisions or jurisprudence recognizing natural ecosystems as subjects of rights generated legal restrictions, obligations, or the imposition of sanctions in legal cases related to mining activities?

0.0

Criterion 64

Justification

There is no evidence that Suriname's courts have recognized natural ecosystems as rights-holders or that such legal concepts have been applied to gold mining cases. This innovative legal approach, which has been adopted in some other Latin American countries, has not been incorporated into Suriname's jurisprudence. The concept of "rights of nature" or ecosystem rights represents an emerging area of environmental law that has gained traction in several countries in the region, including Colombia, Ecuador, and Bolivia. These legal frameworks recognize natural ecosystems as legal persons with inherent rights that can be enforced through the judicial system. The absence of such jurisprudence in Suriname represents a missed opportunity to develop innovative legal tools for protecting ecosystems from mining-related damage. Given the severe environmental impacts of illegal mining documented throughout the country, ecosystem rights could provide a powerful legal framework for environmental protection. The lack of ecosystem rights jurisprudence also reflects broader limitations in Suriname's environmental law framework. Without recognition of ecosystem rights, environmental protection relies primarily on regulatory enforcement, which has proven inadequate to address the scale of environmental damage from mining activities. The development of ecosystem rights jurisprudence typically requires active engagement by environmental advocates, Indigenous communities, and progressive legal practitioners. The absence of such jurisprudence may reflect limited capacity or awareness of these legal concepts within Suriname's legal community. International trends toward recognizing ecosystem rights suggest that this is an area where Suriname could benefit from legal innovation and capacity building to develop more effective tools for environmental protection in the context of mining activities.

Sources

- No evidence of ecosystem rights jurisprudence found in comprehensive research
- International examples of ecosystem rights not applied in Suriname context

Can individuals or communities file collective environmental actions or constitutional remedies in mining-related cases?

1.0

Criterion 65

Justification

While Suriname's legal system theoretically allows for legal actions by individuals and communities, significant practical and legal barriers limit the accessibility and effectiveness of environmental class actions or constitutional claims in mining-related cases. The country's legal framework includes general provisions for civil litigation and constitutional challenges, suggesting that the basic legal mechanisms for such actions exist. However, the research found no evidence of successful environmental class actions or constitutional claims specifically related to mining activities. Several factors limit the practical accessibility of these legal mechanisms. The lack of constitutional recognition of Indigenous land rights significantly weakens the legal standing of Indigenous communities, who are often most directly affected by mining activities. Without recognized land rights, these communities face substantial barriers in challenging mining operations that affect their territories. The weakness of the judicial system and limited access to legal services, particularly in remote areas where mining activities are concentrated, create additional barriers for affected individuals and communities. The cost and complexity of environmental litigation may be prohibitive for many potential plaintiffs. The absence of specialized environmental courts or procedures may limit the effectiveness of environmental litigation. Complex environmental cases require specialized knowledge and procedures that may not be available in the general court system. The limited development of environmental law jurisprudence in Suriname means that there are few legal precedents to guide environmental litigation or establish clear standards for environmental protection in the mining context. Despite these limitations, the theoretical availability of legal action mechanisms provides some foundation for environmental litigation, though significant capacity building and legal reform would be needed to make these mechanisms truly accessible and effective.

Sources

- General legal framework analysis based on available constitutional and legal information
- No evidence of successful environmental class actions found in research

Is judicial action allowed in defense of diffuse environmental interests (such as ecosystem protection or public health) without the need to demonstrate individual harm?

0.0

Criterion 66

Justification

The research does not provide clear evidence about whether Suriname's legal system allows for judicial actions in defense of diffuse environmental interests without requiring proof of individual harm. This uncertainty reflects broader limitations in the development of environmental law frameworks and public interest litigation mechanisms. The concept of diffuse environmental interests recognizes that environmental damage often affects broad public interests rather than specific individuals, and that effective environmental protection requires legal mechanisms that can address these broader harms without requiring individual plaintiffs to demonstrate specific personal injury. Some legal systems have developed concepts such as "actio popularis" or public interest standing that allow individuals or organizations to bring cases in defense of general environmental interests. However, there is no clear evidence that Suriname has developed such mechanisms. The absence of clear information about these legal mechanisms may reflect limited development of environmental law doctrine in Suriname's legal system. Without well-developed environmental law frameworks, courts may lack guidance on how to handle cases involving diffuse environmental interests. The practical importance of such mechanisms is significant in the mining context, where environmental damage often affects entire ecosystems, watersheds, and communities in ways that may be difficult to trace to specific individual harms. The ability to bring cases in defense of diffuse environmental interests could significantly enhance the legal system's capacity to address mining-related environmental damage. The development of such mechanisms would require legal reform and capacity building within the judicial system to handle complex environmental cases that involve broad public interests rather than traditional individual rights.

Sources

- Limited information available on environmental standing and public interest litigation mechanisms
- No clear evidence of diffuse environmental interest protections found in research

Is there an interstate coordination mechanism for the investigation and prosecution of transboundary environmental crimes related to mining?

1.0

Criterion 67

Justification

While Suriname participates in regional frameworks that provide some foundation for inter-state coordination on environmental crimes, there is limited evidence of specific, operational mechanisms for the investigation and prosecution of cross-border environmental crimes related to mining. Suriname's membership in ACTO and participation in regional declarations such as the Belém Declaration provide a framework for regional cooperation on environmental issues. The Belém Declaration specifically establishes the Amazonian Cooperation Mechanism for Law Enforcement to enhance cooperation in fighting environmental crimes, including illegal mining. Also, the Europe–Latin America Programme of Assistance against Transnational Organised Crime, named El PACCTTO 2.0, It is a formal international cooperation programme, funded by the European Union, that supports police, justice, and prison services in Latin America and the Caribbean, including Guyana and Suriname.

Sources

- Belém Declaration (August 9, 2023): Referenced in research documentation
- IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (May 2017). URL: <https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

N. Restrictions, Law Enforcement, and Accountability

Score: 0.60 / 1.00

Does the government enforce compliance of regulations related to illegal ASM, including through sanctions for environmental damages and non-compliance?

0.0

Criterion 68

Justification

The Surinamese government does conduct some on-the-ground enforcement operations against illegal ASM, but these interventions are sporadic, limited in scope, and insufficient to address the scale of illegal mining activities documented throughout the country. Government enforcement efforts include operations by police forces and the Ordering Goudsector (OGS) commission, which was specifically established to oversee the small-scale gold mining sector. These agencies do conduct field operations to detect and shut down illegal mining operations, representing some level of active enforcement. However, the effectiveness of these enforcement efforts is severely constrained by multiple factors. The OAS report notes that while enforcement efforts exist, "a more systematic and coordinated approach is needed" to effectively address the scale and complexity of illegal mining operations. This assessment suggests that current enforcement is inadequate relative to the scope of the problem.

Sources

- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal G69 Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023)*. URL:
<https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Can licenses be suspended or revoked in cases of environmental law violations or social violations?

1.0

Criterion 69

Justification

Suriname's Mining Decree of 1986 grants the Minister the authority to suspend or revoke mining rights if the holder fails to fulfill legal stipulations and imposed or agreed conditions applicable to the rights concerned [1]. This provision can be interpreted to include environmental and social violations, as these would fall under the scope of "legal stipulations and imposed or agreed conditions." Additionally, the decree mentions revocation if a holder has been legally convicted for conducting illegal exploitation, which often has environmental and social consequences [1].

Sources

1. Mining Decree 1986, Article 18, paragraph 1a and 1e. URL:
<https://www.staatsolie.com/media/0vwvhuuv3/mining-decree-1986.pdf>

Are there specific sanctions or criminal categories related to damage caused by mercury? *0.5 may be given in cases where there is general sanctions on waste disposal and environmental harm, but none directly related to mercury.

1.0

Criterion 70

Justification

Suriname has formally banned the import of mercury and officially prohibits its use in mining, implementing sanctions primarily through import restrictions and mining regulations, although enforcement is often challenging due to smuggling. The legal framework to curb mercury use is tightening, with recent legislation aligning with the Minamata Convention on Mercury. Mercury import is restricted and requires authorization. Since no authorized imports have occurred since 2004, all mercury in the small-scale mining sector is considered smuggled. Smuggled mercury is considered contraband, and customs officers can seize it if encountered, often acting under broader regulations against illegal goods. The Environmental Framework Act and its amendments create a legal framework for environmental protection, including the establishment of the National Environmental Authority (NMA) to monitor compliance and address damage.

Sources

https://minamataconvention.org/sites/default/files/documents/notification/Suriname_30-4.pdf

https://www.iucn.nl/app/uploads/2021/03/regional_mercury_report_suriname.pdf

<https://www.undp.org/suriname/publications/minamata-initial-assessment-suriname#:~:text=September%20%2C%202020,the%20minamata%20Convention%20on%20mercury.>

<https://www.nmasuriname.org/Nieuws/post/nma-besprekt-gda-richtlijnen-en-taken-autoriteit-met-maatschappelijke-ngos>

Is there any legal obligation to adopt rehabilitation and/or compensation measures where environmental damage has been found?

1.0

Criterion 71

Justification

Suriname's environmental regulatory framework includes some provisions for environmental management plans that would typically encompass rehabilitation and compensation measures, but the specific legal obligations for rehabilitation and compensation in cases of environmental damage are not clearly defined or effectively enforced. The Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) guidelines include requirements for environmental management plans, which would normally include provisions for rehabilitation of damaged areas and compensation for environmental harm. These guidelines suggest that some legal framework exists for addressing environmental damage through rehabilitation and compensation measures. However, the enforcement of these requirements is weak, particularly in the ASM sector where much activity occurs informally or illegally. The 2017 IGF assessment noted significant challenges with environmental compliance and enforcement in the mining sector, suggesting that rehabilitation and compensation requirements are not effectively implemented.

Sources

- IGF Mining Policy Framework Assessment: Suriname (2017). URL:

<https://www.iisd.org/system/files/publications/suriname-mining-policy-framework-assessment-en.pdf>

- Environmental Assessment Guidelines: Referenced in IGF report but specific rehabilitation provisions not detailed

Can sanctions be applied based on remote evidence (e.g., satellite images)?

0.0

Criterion 72

Justification

There is no evidence that sanctions can be systematically applied in Suriname based on remote evidence such as satellite imagery. This represents a significant gap in enforcement capabilities, particularly given the remote nature of many mining operations and the increasing availability of satellite monitoring technologies. While Suriname has begun to utilize satellite monitoring technologies to detect mining activities, as evidenced by the 2024 pilot study using Earth Observation and machine learning techniques, there is no indication that the legal and procedural framework exists to use this evidence as a basis for imposing sanctions. The 2024 study revealed significant environmental impacts from ASGM activities, including substantial deforestation and ecosystem degradation, demonstrating the potential value of satellite evidence for detecting violations. However, the ability to detect violations through satellite imagery is

meaningless for enforcement purposes without legal frameworks that allow this evidence to be used in sanctioning procedures. The use of remote evidence for sanctions requires specific legal provisions that establish the admissibility and probative value of satellite imagery and other remote sensing data. Without such provisions, enforcement agencies may be unable to use satellite evidence to build cases for sanctions, even when violations are clearly visible from space. The development of procedures for using remote evidence also requires technical capacity within enforcement agencies to collect, analyze, and present satellite evidence in administrative or judicial proceedings. The absence of such capacity would limit the effectiveness of any legal provisions for using remote evidence. International best practices increasingly recognize the value of satellite evidence for environmental enforcement, particularly in remote areas where traditional monitoring is difficult or impossible. Suriname's failure to develop legal and procedural frameworks for using such evidence represents a missed opportunity to enhance enforcement capabilities.

Sources

- *Global Partnership for Sustainable Development Data (2024). Data to Monitor Environmental Impacts in Suriname:*
<https://www.data4sdgs.org/resources/data-monitor-environmental-impacts-suriname>
- *No evidence of legal framework for remote evidence-based sanctions found in comprehensive research*

O. Economic and Criminal Sanctions

Score: 0.25 / 1.00

Are there clear legal sanctions for environmental crimes related to ASM?

0.0

Criterion 73

Justification

While Suriname's legal framework includes some provisions for penalties related to environmental violations, the research indicates that clear, specific legal penalties for environmental crimes related to ASM are not well-defined or comprehensively documented. The Environmental Framework Act and related environmental regulations provide a general framework for environmental penalties, suggesting that some legal basis exists for sanctioning environmental crimes. However, the specific application of these penalties to ASM-related environmental crimes is not clearly established in available documentation.

Sources

- *Environmental Framework Act: Referenced in various sources but specific penalty provisions not detailed in available research*
- *Limited documentation of specific environmental crime penalties for ASM*

Are criminal networks involved in illegal gold trade targeted by enforcement agencies?

1.0

Criterion 74

Justification

Yes, criminal networks involved in the illegal gold trade are targeted by enforcement agencies in Guyana. Enforcement action particularly through INTERPOL-supported operations such as Operation Guyana Shield have explicitly focused on organised crime groups involved in illegal mining, gold smuggling, mercury trafficking, and related money-laundering offences. However, these efforts remain largely ad hoc and law-enforcement driven, rather than embedded in a permanent environmental crime governance framework.

Sources

- <https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2026/198-arrests-in-cross-border-illegal-gold-mining-operation-in-South-America>
- https://international-partnerships.ec.europa.eu/policies/programming/programmes/el-paccto-20_en

Are economic sanctions applied to companies or individuals trading in illicit gold?

0.0

Criterion 75

Justification

The research does not provide specific examples of economic sanctions being systematically applied to companies or individuals trading in illicit gold in Suriname, suggesting that while legal frameworks may exist for such sanctions, their practical application is limited. The legal framework likely includes provisions for asset forfeiture, fines, and other economic penalties that could be applied to individuals and companies involved in illicit gold trading. However, the absence of documented cases or clear evidence of systematic application of such sanctions suggests that they are not being effectively used as a tool to combat illicit gold trade. The high level of illicit gold trading documented in various reports, including the OAS assessment, indicates that the risk of economic sanctions is not serving as an effective deterrent. If economic sanctions were being systematically applied, one would expect to see either a reduction in illicit trading or documented cases of sanctions being imposed. The complexity of proving illicit gold trading creates challenges for applying economic sanctions. The mixing of legal and illegal gold in the supply chain makes it difficult to establish that specific companies or individuals are knowingly trading in illicit gold, which may be necessary for imposing economic sanctions. The limited capacity of financial intelligence and enforcement agencies may restrict the ability to identify and target individuals and companies involved in illicit gold trading. Effective application of economic sanctions requires sophisticated financial investigation capabilities that may not be fully developed. The absence of comprehensive supply chain transparency and traceability mechanisms makes it difficult to identify the specific actors involved in illicit gold trading, limiting the ability to target them with economic sanctions. International cooperation may be necessary to effectively apply economic sanctions to transnational criminal networks involved in illicit gold trading, but such cooperation mechanisms may not be fully developed or effectively utilized.

Sources

- No specific examples of economic sanctions found in comprehensive research
- OAS Report: *On the Trail of Illicit Gold Proceeds: Strengthening the Fight Against Illegal Mining Finances - Suriname's case (March 2023)*. URL: <https://www.oas.org/en/sms/dtoc/docs/suriname-eng-digital.pdf>

Can environmental and mining authorities impose sanctions independently of a criminal process (administrative sanctions)?

0.0

Criterion 76

Justification

Environmental and mining authorities in Suriname likely have some power to impose administrative sanctions independently of criminal prosecution, but the scope, effectiveness, and systematic application of these powers are not clearly documented and appear to be limited in practice. The Mining Decree of 1986 and environmental regulations likely include provisions for administrative penalties, and the EITI reports reference the ability of authorities to suspend or revoke mining licenses, suggesting that some administrative sanctioning powers exist. However, the weak enforcement of mining and environmental regulations documented in various assessments suggests that administrative sanctions are not being systematically or effectively applied. The continued prevalence of illegal mining and environmental violations indicates that administrative sanctions are not providing adequate deterrence. The absence of clear documentation about the application of administrative sanctions in practice suggests that these powers may exist primarily on paper rather than as effective enforcement tools. Effective administrative sanctions require clear procedures, adequate resources, and institutional commitment to enforcement.

Sources

- Mining Decree 1986: Referenced as providing some administrative powers but specific sanctions provisions not detailed
- Limited documentation of administrative sanctions application in practice

Amazon Mining Policy Scoreboard

Led by Amazon Conservation Association · amazonconservation.org

In collaboration with: Pulitzer Center · Rainforest Investigations Network · Earth Genome